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Sunday
October 4, 2026
THE HINDU

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RWA IN TAMBARAM SEEKS REVIEW OF PROPERTY TAX

Judge Colony and Neighbourhood Welfare Association raises concerns over drainage, groundwater contamination and road safety **P3**



A HOBBY EVOLVES TO MEET GEN ZERS ON THEIR TERMS

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters **P4**

Stairs to be constructed for easy access to footbridge

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

If all paper work related to constructing a footbridge approach stairs goes smoothly then access to Chromepet terminal from Radha Nagar Main Road will be easy and safe.

D. Mohana Priya, an Indian Railway Traffic Service officer and Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Chennai Division, said Southern Railway will soon start work on constructing a footbridge approach stairs connecting to its footbridge across Chromepet terminal.

Speaking to members of Chromepet Rail Users' Forum at a meeting organised by the Division, she said the facility will be constructed along the parking lot along Radha Nagar Main Road.



At the meet organised by Chromepet Rail Users' Forum and Southern Railway.

The facility, to be constructed at a cost of more than ₹ 1 crore, will have a lift for those unable to access the bridge by stairs.

To reach the ticket counters and platforms, commuters must use the walkway in the Radha Nagar vehicular subway and access the double-discharge platform. This creates a roundabout route to reach the platforms and the booking office, says V. Santhanam, founder of the Chromepet Rail Users' Forum.

Currently, as part of the renovation work happening at the terminal, a lift would be facilitated along GST Road eastern lane, and a booking office on double discharge platform. The work is expected to be completed by February.

Restore Veeraraghavan Eri to store rainwater



We The Change People's Movement, Thiruneermalai and People's Awareness Association in Chromepet recently took up an exercise to weed water hyacinth from Veeraraghavan Eri, spread across Chromepet and Tambaram Sanatorium regions.

The gathering raised slogans demanding that Tambaram City Municipal Corporation restore the waterbody before the onset of the monsoon to store rainwater. They also requested the Water Resources Department to form bunds in the Thiruneermalai Periya Eri in accordance with the Field Measurement Book, and restore the 'Nattu Kalvai' channel.

Veeraraghavan Eri is filled with water hyacinth due to discharge of sewage from homes in the regions.

For years, local residents have repeatedly asked the civic body to rejuvenate the lake.

The restoration of the waterbody will help recharge the ground water level in Chromepet and Tambaram Sanatorium regions, Government Hospital of Thoracic Medicine, National Institute of Siddha, Government Hospitals (Dental and General), Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited, and the State Fire Service State Training Center, Tambaram Sanatorium.

V. Santhanam, founder of People's Awareness Association, says, "The groundwater will be depleted if the lake is not saved. The Water Resources Department should have restored the Veeraraghavan Eri, followed by Thiruneermalai Eri. At Periya Eri, restoration work is going on, and as a part of this, the lake was desilted, deepened and bunds formed. The excess water from the Veeraraghavan Eri entered Periya Eri and lake bunds were washed away. Unless Veeraraghavan Eri is restored, Thiruneermalai Periya Eri restoration work cannot be fruitful."



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New RWA in Tambaram seeks review of property tax

Judge Colony and Neighbourhood Welfare Association raises concerns over drainage, groundwater contamination and road safety

T. ARVIND

The newly formed Judge Colony and Neighbourhood Welfare Association, an initiative of the United Federation of Residents Welfare Associations in Tambaram City Corporation, has raised concerns over high property tax rates, groundwater contamination, inadequate drainage, poor roads and road safety.

The association was formally inaugurated on September 27 in the presence of more than 100 residents. It has also submitted a memorandum to the Chief Minister's Special Cell and the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department (MAWS) seeking action on the issues.





Poor condition of the road near Krishnan Koil junction and a street in Sriram Colony. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Property tax burden

One of the major issues raised by the association was the property tax rates in Tambaram Corporation. S.M. Govindarajan, social activist, said the property tax revised by the Corporation in 2024 was significantly higher than that in several premium localities in Greater Chennai.

According to Govindarajan, the property tax for a 1,500 sq ft residential building in Zone A of Tambaram Corporation was ₹26,812.65, which he said was 65% higher than the tax for a comparable property on Boat Club Road and 164% higher than that on North Usman Road, despite the latter having a lower guideline value.

He said Chitlapakkam residents were facing a disproportionately high property tax burden despite relatively lower guideline values.

He also said that, as per local body norms, an Appeals Committee comprising the Mayor/Commissioner and councillors, irrespective of political affiliation, should be in place. "There is no information on this and there was no public consultation or discussion among councillors before revising the tax rates," he said. "Despite writing to Tambaram Corporation on this issue, zero action has been taken to date. Residents are forced to face a second property tax hike of 178%-550%, well above the 25%-100% ceiling fixed by the MAWS in G.O. 52 of March 2022," he said.

The association said it hoped for a positive response to its memorandum. Till then, it urged the Corporation to refrain from fixing a deadline for payment of the revised property tax.

Civic and safety concerns

Residents of Sriram Colony expressed concern over possible groundwater contamination by septic water and persistent drainage problems. According to Govindarajan, streets in Sriram Colony, in Ward 34, Zone 3, Tambaram Sanatorium, were flooded even during gentle downpours. As the area was low-lying and lacked stormwater drains, inundation during the rainy season posed serious problems.

Residents also raised concerns over public safety near Krishnan Kovil and Thozhi Hostel, particularly after street lights were switched off. The association decided to take up the issue with the authorities and seek measures to improve street lighting and public safety.

The poor condition of Chitlapakkam Main Road, a bus route and a State highway, and the Krishnan Kovil junction was another concern. Residents said uneven patches of concrete blocks and potholes posed a threat to motorists, particularly during peak hours.

The association said it was surprised to receive a response from the Corporation Commissioner that the road would be re-laid "within three months" after the issue was raised.

Residents also sought modification of the unusually high speed-breakers near a government school, saying they did not conform to Indian Roads Congress norms. They suggested reflective paint or markings to improve visibility at night.

Activists also pointed to the death of a 34-year-old motorist in Chitlapakkam in 2024 in connection with an unmarked speed-breaker, and alleged that road safety norms continued to be flouted.

Golden jubilee reunion of Nehru GHSS



The 1976 SSLC Batch Students' Forum of Nehru Government Higher Secondary School in Nanganallur celebrated its 16th annual meet and 50th year reunion at Blue Lagoon, East Coast Road. Eighty-five friends, including 63 students from the batch (40 boys and 23 girls), attended the celebration with their spouses. They enjoyed swimming and the artificial waterfalls. They played many games, including thambola. Prizes were given to the winners. The forum thanked all the participants and D Viswanathan, who sponsored a five-kilogram vegetarian cake, said a release.

Farmers market comes to Pallikaranai

If you are looking for fresh produce sourced directly from farmers then head to SS Mahal in Pallikaranai today. A new organic farmers markets is being launched from October 4 and will be held on the first Sunday of every month.

Inspired by the success of organic farmers market in T. Nagar, Aram Thinai, a climate action organisation is launching their second Aram Organic Farmers Market in Pallikaranai. Such markets across Chennai are emerging as spaces for conscious consumption, farmer-consumer relationship building and knowledge sharing.

The market has 20-30 stalls of organic farmers, women groups and social entrepreneurs with a range of organic and eco-friendly products. There will be more than 20 varieties of greens, 15 varieties of traditional rice and a range of organic grocery, value added products, eco-friendly cleaning products and some organic dishes. In a release, Karthik G., co-founder, Aram Thinai, said they want to ensure fair price to both farmers and consumers. Like some practices that is followed in its T. Nagar market (held on the second Sunday of every month), this one is also a zero single use plastic market. Consumer have to bring their own containers and bags to buy things and the farmers pack everything in paper covers or glass bottles.

For details, call 8939138207 / 7449138207

Library in memory of Chromepet resident

The family members of late S. Srimathy, wife of social activist V. Santhanam, who passed away last month, are constructing a library in her memory.

The library is being built on the premises of Ayyasamy Iyer Higher Secondary School at Nehru Nagar in Chromepet to benefit students of classes X, XI, and XII.

A bhoomi puja was held recently to mark the beginning of construction, and foundation work is currently under way.

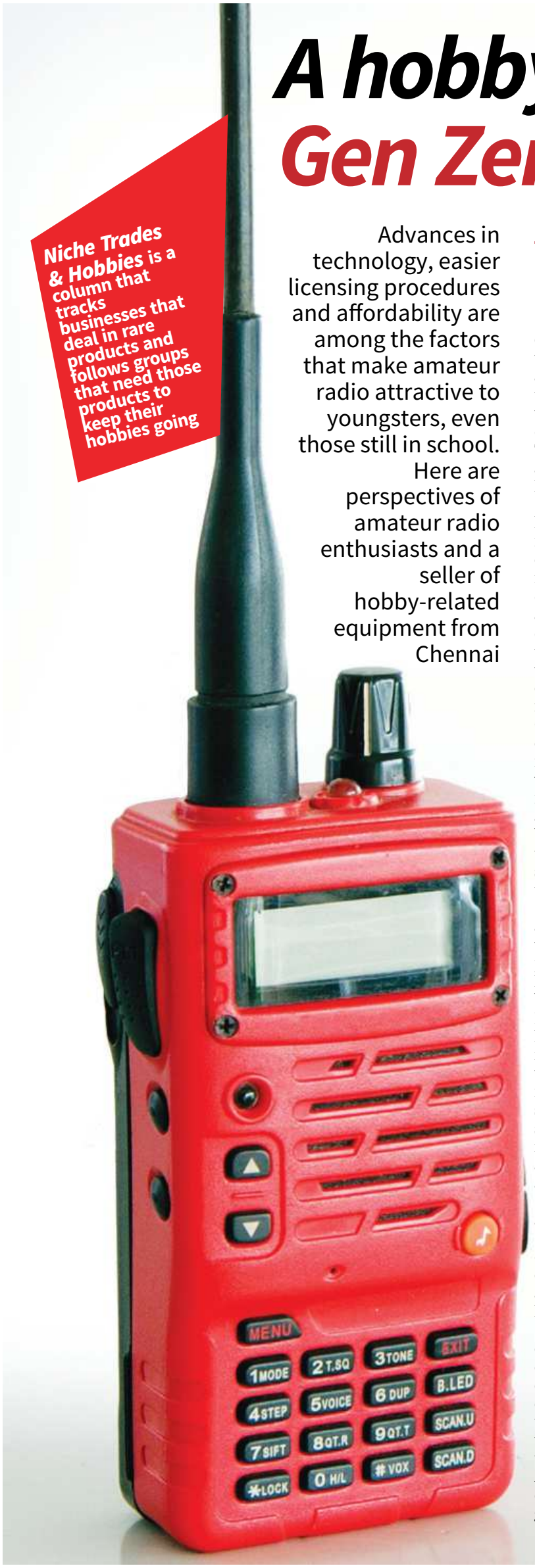
The library will feature books, newspapers and magazines donated by V. Santhanam and his youngest son, S. Sridhar.

The construction work is expected to be completed by February. Those interested in donating books can contact V. Santhanam at 9444254850.

Niche Trades & Hobbies is a column that tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going

A hobby evolves to meet Gen Zers on their terms

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There is usually an apocalyptic air to how Ham radio is perceived. The Ham radio enthusiast is readily visualised as trudging into a land overtaken by a massive disaster and where all technology-based communication lines outside the amateur-radio sphere have broken down. The enthusiast has morphed into a saviour, connecting with a fellow hobbyist elsewhere in the "universe" and communicating a local situation, dire and distressing, amidst the static and crackle of radio communication, to reach help to the suffering. This description is indeed fact-aligned. Ham radio enthusiasts do take centre stage during disasters. One witnessed that during the Kerala floods of 2018 and closer home, in the harrowing first week of December 2015 in Chennai. But distress communication is only one of the things riding on amateur radio air waves. Net sessions (as on-air meetups of Ham radio hobbyists are known) are also defined by banter, in fact, more by small talk than SOS calls. And do not be surprised if the banter is punctuated with Gen Z lingo.

N. Deepan (call sign VU2DPN), a key member of Madras Amatuer Radio Society (MARS), points out that the Ham radio hobby has never been as accessible to youngsters as it is now. From licensing to practising the hobby, the procedures of initiation and the operation of the equipment have become ridiculously simple. Having seen 63 summers and getting started on the hobby around four decades ago, Deepan is at a vantage point to talk about the hobby's evolution.

The Wireless Planning and Coordination wing (WPC) is responsible for conducting Amateur Station Operator's Certificate (ASOC) examination and issuing the license.

Deepan underlines the examinations have become simpler as technology has organically taken certain "subjects" off the table. And the removal of this barrier encourages the entry of youngsters. Anyone aged 12 and above can appear for the exam and get the license. "Where it took one or two years to get a license, it takes approximately one month," observes Deepan, noting that objective questions have replaced the earlier pattern of examination.

And the new license holder can hit the ground running, the process of getting started on the hobby also having become facile. EchoLink, Z3 DMR, and Droidstar allow licensed operators to communicate using just a phone with other amateur radio enthusiasts. Once the license is validated, usually within 24 hours, the software can be used. And that obviates the need to invest in ham radio equipment; that can wait. Deepan has seen the ham radio equipment move from valves to transistors, ICs and now Software Defined Radio (SDR). With advancing technology, the equipment has shrunk, and so has their prices. Deepan attributes the fall in prices to the shift from imported equipment to local dealerships (to sell ham radio equipment, a dealer's license is required).

That brings us to someone like Gaurav Srivatsava and his wife Shivangi Gaurav, both ham radio license holders and diehard enthusiasts, and beyond that, owners of Radio Brewery in Iyyapanthangal (radiobrewery.com), which sells amatuer radio equipment. Shivangi largely manages the business while Gaurav continues to work in the IT sector. Their own personal struggles in finding reliable and cost-effective equipment locally had crystallised into this business venture in 2018. Gaurav recalls that besides importing, Ham radio enthusiasts in Chennai were dependent on a couple of dealers in Delhi. The hobbyists would together buy in bulk to keep prices within their comfort range. Among those who encouraged them to start this business was Deepan, one of Gaurav's mentors and supporters.



Malini D

Among factors that augur well for the hobby, Gaurav says, is the portability of the ham radio gear. He recalls the time when valve radios, measuring six by six feet, "appropriated" a room in exchange for the joy of communicating on amateur radio air waves. Fast forward to now, a low-powered ham radio equipment can "fit into a small bread box". Deepan notes that even if one were to route their ham radio communication through an amateur radio satellite, the allied equipment, which includes SDR dongle, dish antenna and up converter or transverter, is easy on the back, being eminently portable. Both Deepan and Gaurav have noticed youngsters taking to the hobby. Gaurav points out his daughter Pari Gaurav (VI2JXB/ KN6GRI, US amateur radio identifier ID), 19 years old now, cleared the WPC examination at age 12. Deepan's daughter, Malini D. (VU3JJT) is also an avid ham radio enthusiast. Even youngsters without any precedent of ham radio engagement in their families are gravitating towards the hobby for the doors of communication it opens in various parts of the world. Deepan notes, "On the Net, all radio ham hobbyists connect and converse as equals."

To sum up, this hobby seems to have been made for Gen Zers (and the ones following them too) for two reasons. It is a generation that derives its strength and purpose from communication, even with those they will never meet in real life, and this hobby is geared to that. And two, this generation thrives on volunteering, and this hobby can provide opportunities for that during extremely harrowing times.

Deadly 'gaps' at Guindy railway station



P. SATHYANARAYANAN

Recently, at Guindy railway terminal, an alert Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel pulled a senior citizen to safety after the latter had fallen into the gap between the train and the platform. The train dragged him for a few metres

Mainline Electrical Multiple Units should not be operated on suburban train tracks.

The platforms are constructed in such a way that there is a huge gap between the entry/exit area of the train and the platform. The platforms at St. Thomas Mount railway station are similarly dangerous.

Commuters have to watch their steps while entraining and detraining.

In addition, the trains halt at the station for only 30 seconds. The train should not move until the station master and the railway staff raise and wave the green flag. Railway staff should be deployed at various points of the platform.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a veteran social activist, and a long-time resident of Guindy

'Clear the garbage soon'



R. RAJASHREE

After years, Southern Railway recently started removing trash as well as bushes along Bharathi Nagar and Race View Colony in Guindy, which is a welcome move. But the railway should clear the removed trash and bushes immediately. An unturned cigarette or a lighted matchstick thrown can cause a huge fire along the compound walls. The exercise should be carried out regularly.

R. Rajashree is a resident of Guindy

Strengthening academia-industry connection



B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology recently hosted an international industry collaboration and offer letter presentation ceremony with Crescent Global Outreach Mission (CGOM) and ADEEB Group, marking a significant step toward strengthening international industry-academia partnerships and creating global career opportunities for students. Ansari Wahid, Chief Executive Officer, ADEEB Group, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, was the chief guest.

The ceremony focused on strengthening international industry collaboration and enhancing students' exposure to global employment opportunities.

Through this association, the institution is creating avenues for students to connect with international organisations, understand global industry expectations, and develop the skills needed to build successful careers beyond national boundaries, a release said.

A key highlight of the programme was the presentation of offer letters to the selected students.

The interactions emphasised the importance of industry-academia collaboration, international exposure, employability enhancement, and global career development in preparing students for the evolving demands of the international workforce, the release added.

Learners drive learning at Kelambakkam school

Recently, Chettinad - Sarvalokaa Education International School, located within the green Chettinad Health City campus in Kelambakkam, organised a Learner-Led Conference (LLC) which places learners at the centre of their learning journey, encouraging them to confidently present, explain and reflect on their experiences while developing agency and ownership.

According to a press release, the initiative reflects the school's broader approach to experiential and collaborative learning, nurturing communication, confidence, problem-solving, reflection and real-world skills beyond academics.

The press release adds that unlike a traditional parent-teacher meeting, a learner-led conference gives learners the responsibility to present, explain and reflect on what they have learnt. Learners speak about their understanding, challenges, progress and experiences, thereby developing learner agency - the ability to make choices, take responsibility and actively participate in their own learning

Chettinad - Sarvalokaa Education International School is a Nature- integrated Cambridge International school that places strong emphasis on joyful, experiential and holistic learning, says the press release.

Rally on heart health



In observance of World Heart Day, VS Hospitals organised a four-km rally to spread awareness on heart health. On the occasion, the hospital launched its emergency helpline number 044 - 69698000.

According to a press release, former DGP C. Sylendra Babu flagged off the event at VS Hospitals, Tondiarpet, in the presence of Dr. S. Subramanian Chairman and Managing Director, VS Hospitals, Dr. S. Sundar, Medical Director, Muthu Subramanian, Executive Director, and Prassanna Srinivasan, Group COO.

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On A Gobal Stage
is a column about residents of Chennai currently in the spotlight at a global event

Never too late to start afresh

R. RAGU

In cricket, one regularly comes across teams that shift to a whole new lane in the second innings, with surprising progress, eclipsing their first-innings performance. And in that process, they bring immense joy and wonder to spectators.

Seshadri Sukumar has pulled off something similar to that.

Here are the details of 71-year-old Seshadri's second innings: a Press Information Bureau-accredited international sports photographer from Chennai and a Canon EOS Ambassador. He now has a reputation for "checking into" major international sporting events. As this article is being written, he is shooting images of sporting excellence at the 20th Asian Games, unfolding at Aichi Prefecture and Nagaya in Japan.



Before zooming in on what he is doing now, a quick run of his first innings: Sukumar had been working in the banking sector, being an official photographer with Indian Overseas Bank (IOB). He always had an intense desire to be a sports photographer, but that remained a desire for a drearily long time.

When retirement from corporate career was looming large, Sukumar took the plunge and started pursuing sports photography full steam ahead.

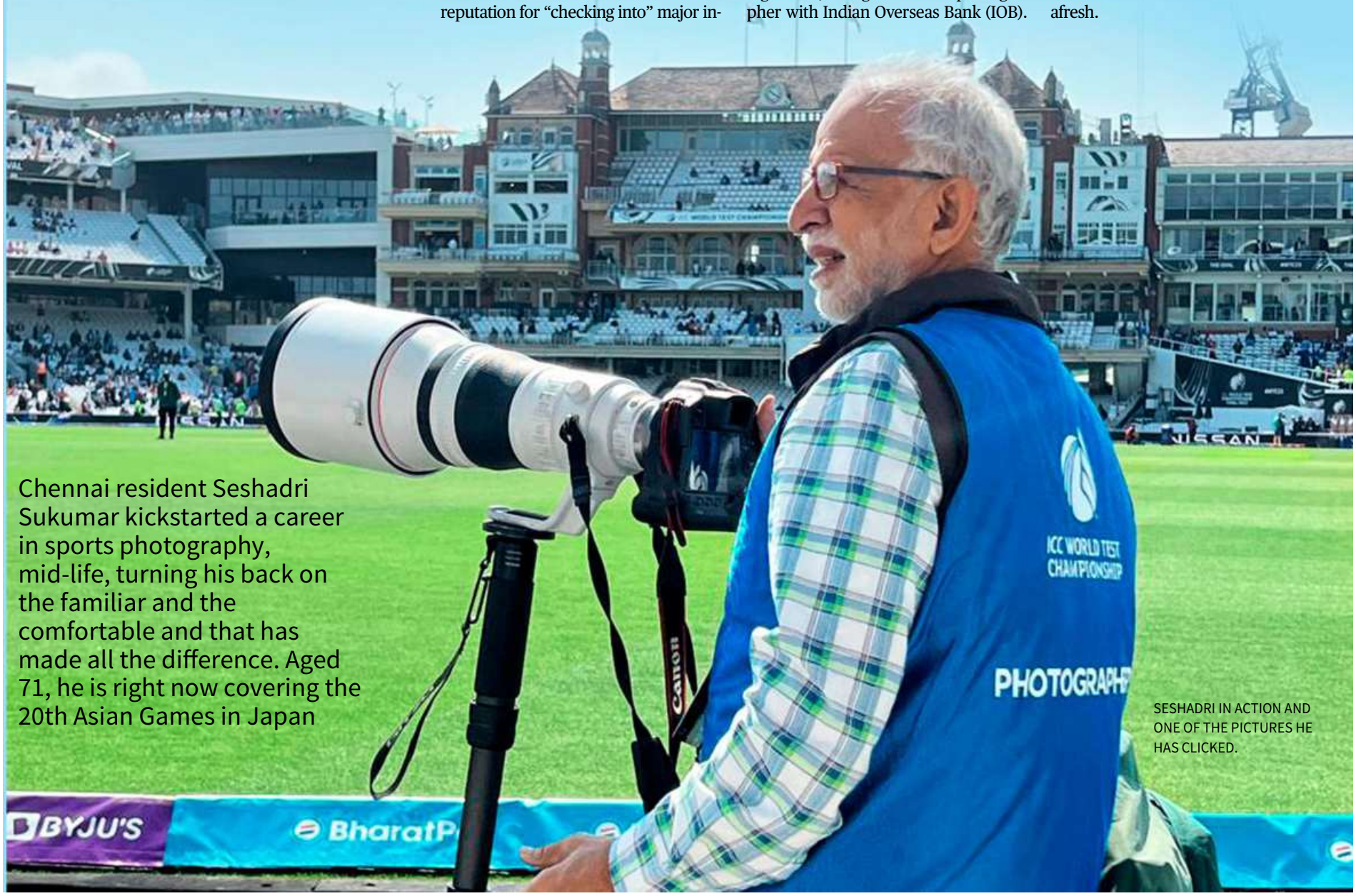
After Sukumar has been years into sports photography, in 2021, Sukumar's nephew shared a story about his uncle's passion for sports photography, online. Sukumar was 66 years old then and covering the Tokyo Olympic Games. And the story of how someone is flourishing in a career kickstarted mid-life caught the world's imagination.

Sukuamar's portfolio includes multiple Olympic Games, FIFA World Cups (including the most recent edition), ICC World Cups, Grand Slam tournaments, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, NBA events, FINA World Championships, FIDE World Cups and MotoGP, among several other major sporting events.

Among his iconic photographs is one the Rio Olympics, one that captured the contrasting emotions of the winner and the loser; the photograph won his a gold medal from the Photographic Society of America (PSA).

Sukumar's professional photographs have been distributed through international wire services and stock photography libraries, including Alamy, Zuma Press, IMAGO Images, SOPA Images and Reuters Connect.

Sukumar's life and career are a reminder that it is never too late to start afresh.



Chennai resident Seshadri Sukumar kickstarted a career in sports photography, mid-life, turning his back on the familiar and the comfortable and that has made all the difference. Aged 71, he is right now covering the 20th Asian Games in Japan

SESHADRI IN ACTION AND ONE OF THE PICTURES HE HAS CLICKED.